

1 OBESITY

1.1 Stigmatization of obesity

Obesity has always been a condition in which people are routinely labeled and stereotyped as undisciplined or mentally weak. It has become one of the most stigmatized health conditions, especially in the United States. People who are identified as obese typically experience judgement, blame, and possibly even assumptions about their character and self control. Research on weight stigma has proven that many people with obesity are labeled as lazy or undisciplined, and these stereotypes are constantly around their lives (Puhl & Heuer, 2009). Judgement against people with obesity is so prevalent that it can impact how these individuals receive care for this health condition. Many individuals would avoid medical care because they expect shaming comments or refuse to exercise in public due to fear of being judged. This process simply perpetuates a system in which people who are obese will continually not receive proper medical care for their situation and in turn worsen their health. A major part of obesity stigma is the idea behind weight and looks. Society deems that the way a person looks is completely their responsibility and so people with obesity are seen as choosing their condition instead of living a healthy lifestyle. They are believed to accept their lack of control and decided to rather be lazy. Even though decades of research has shown that a large variety of factors impact how a person's weight and body is affected by genetics, environment, stress, and biology, society often treats obesity as a moral flaw instead. While the physical aspect of obesity can already be demanding, the psychological effects of the stigma can also be painful. People with obesity have been shown to feel ashamed, anxious, or even guilty about their bodies even though they are trying to make changes. The stigma of obesity and weight have been seen to be directly linked to depression and low self esteem. The obesity stigma has been so widespread that individuals tend to internalize the stereotypes about themselves and fall into a cycle of depression and poor eating habits. Breaking away from such a situation can be difficult because the stigmatization of obesity affects people emotionally, socially, and

medically, and society has shown that the stigma more often than not defines how these individuals receive care for obesity.

1.2 Socioeconomic status & neighborhood effects

Looking at obesity from the standpoint of socioeconomic status, we can clearly see an underlying effect that economics have on individuals with obesity. Socioeconomic status is a macro level determinant that can affect the access to healthy food, health care, safe spaces for physical activity, and digital technologies for assistance. Low income families are often restricted by expensive healthy foods and must eat junk food and fast food for convenience and finances. With limited access to affordable groceries and safe exercise locations, people living in low income neighborhoods will most certainly find it more difficult to keep up a healthy lifestyle. Due to these factors, people with obesity in low SES groups tend to be impacted more from the emotional effects of the stigma and the constraints that come along with low economics that could help combat obesity. These people are often blamed for conditions that are out of their control such as the environment they live in and the inability for better food. These barriers means people with obesity may internalize the failure more, which ultimately creates depression and guilt that stops them from seeking help and improving their condition. On the other hand, people in higher income neighborhoods have greater access to beneficial systems that fight obesity such as healthy grocery stores, gyms, safe exercise locations, and digital interventions that support healthy behaviors. This is supported by research showing that social and economic resources determine who benefits from new health knowledge and technologies and people in low SES neighborhoods face greater barriers and few opportunities (Chung et al., 2022). No matter how much healthy habits and nutritious food is recommended, without the feasibility to properly exercise or obtain healthy food, people will not be able to combat obesity. There is a clear difference in difficulty for people with obesity based on socioeconomic status since the structural, financial, and emotional barriers people experience are vastly different. The stigma of obesity ultimately skews how society affects people with obesity and socioeconomic status restricts how much control people actually have over combatting obesity itself.

2 TECHNOLOGY EFFECTS

2.1 Digital Health Tools Reduce Stigma

Digital health tools nowadays have many capabilities that are designed to help motivate healthy behavior in its users. Things like apps and bots can be used to develop personalized interventions that promote weight management. These systems can help people feel more supportive and less judgmental because they can adjust recommendations to fit a person's culture, preferences, budget, and lifestyle (Kreuter & Skinner, 2000). These tools are able to suggest better low cost meals for people in low economic situations, or provide safer walking routes and security for people living in dangerous neighborhoods. It can also give specialized messages of encouragement to the user that is unique and more effective than generic pick me ups. This high level of personalization causes a stronger connection to the user and gives a more empathic feel to the application which causes users to feel more understood and motivated rather than blamed. Obesity is such a heavily judged situation that digital health tools need to focus primarily on emphasizing non guilt and encouragement to help its users. If the digital tool focuses on discipline and self control instead of addressing emotional barriers that are developed from the stigma then the digital tool can in turn hurt the user instead and perpetuate the stigma since the user would further ingrain the belief that they chose their condition and should be blamed for it. These tools need to empower the people and help encourage healthy behavior instead of shaming them into healthy options or else it would simply deepen the stigma rather than reducing it.

2.2 Wearable Technology Combats Obesity But Different SES Levels

Wearable devices have been a revolutionary assistance in the help against combatting obesity. The tools themselves act as motivational and reminder equipment to help users be more active. They often track steps, heart rate, sleep, and help remind users to exercise, which support building healthy behaviors. But research has shown that wearable technology is used disproportionately by higher income individuals, and many wearables are not designed with the realities of low SES communities in mind (Chen & Zhu, 2021). The devices all tend to be expensive and outside of the purchasing power of low SES communities. This develops a gap within the technology and heavily skews its usage and purpose towards higher economic level

individuals. The technology itself was designed to help give users the kind of support that is lacking within a community that has a stigma on obesity by delivering all the statistical support needed to be physically active. But with the gap in SES groups, the stigma is now worsened since the group that is being helped by the devices is the group that already has the least barriers and greater support for obesity. That's why, while wearables can support health, they ultimately only support people who are able to afford them and do nothing to help low SES groups dealing with obesity.

2.3 Digital Platforms Build Community But Can Perpetuate Stigma

The stigma of obesity in society is constantly perpetuated through the judgement and shaming that people exercise on a daily basis. Digital platforms and online communities can be seen as an extension of the real world into the digital world, and these communities can both be helpful and negative based on the context of the situation. These digital spaces are a great place for people to join groups and build a strong community. They help people feel less alone and are an excellent source of support that allow users from all over the world to band together and help fight against the stigma. Social capital research shows that supportive networks improve well being, especially in low income communities where in person resources may be limited (Green & Haines, 2015). The potential of benefits coming from digital platforms to helping people with obesity is great since it helps people build connections that counteract the isolation and stigma. However, these platforms can just as easily worsen the stigma if the community goes against a supportive stance on obesity. Unrealistic body ideals, increased shaming, and even harmful advice can all stem from a digital community that does not have good intentions. The misinformation from the internet and online societies can be just as harmful if not more damaging than real life stigma on obesity. Social media and the Internet are so heavily focused on vanity that safe digital communities that help combat obesity are dwindling and weight and image based popularity can severely damage an obese person's point of view. Trends such as before and after transformations and fitness influencers worsen the digital world and build more stigma. Technology can now both mitigate and perpetuate stigma since it can both create communities of support but also harm individuals and worsen the discouragement of healthy behaviors.

3 REFERENCES

1. Puhl, R., & Heuer, C. (2009). *The stigma of obesity: A review and update.*
2. Chung, R., et al. (2022). *Multilevel determinants of digital health equity: A literature synthesis.*
3. Kreuter, M. W., & Skinner, C. S. (2000). *Tailored interventions in public health: Where we've been and where we're going.*
4. Chen, J., & Zhu, S. (2021). *Socioeconomic class in physical activity wearables research and design.*
5. Green, G. P., & Haines, A. (2015). *Fostering social capital in communities.*

I have not used generative AI to prepare this assignment.